

of my browsing. Install it with `yum -y install firefox`.

For lightweight browsing, I use Dillo (www.dillo.org/), which is a very small and fast Web browser using GTK. Dillo is very basic. It's graphical, but has no frames, HTTPS, or JavaScript support. I've used Dillo for a while now, and am satisfied that it is not going to destabilise my system. However, it is not available in standard Yum repositories in CentOS, so it just seemed easier to install it in my Fedora VM. Install with `yum -y install dillo`. Total download size is 3.5 M.

For even more lightweight browsing, there are Lynx (lynx.isc.org/) and ELinks (elinks.or.cz/). Lynx is a text-based Web browser that does not display any images, but does support frames, tables and most other HTML tags. One advantage it has over graphical browsers is speed; Lynx starts and exits quickly, and displays pages swiftly. Install it with `yum install lynx`.

ELinks is another text-based Web browser that's very similar to Lynx in all respects mentioned. Install it with `yum install elinks`.

These text-mode browsers can be very handy when you are interested in content rather than presentation. But why two browsers, you may ask? I have used Lynx for over 15 years. It's reliable, solid and basic. However, its rendering of tables is unattractive and it lacks any sort of JavaScript support. Surprisingly, ELinks does have JavaScript support, so there are sites that can be viewed in ELinks but not in Lynx or Dillo.

I haven't used ELinks for a long time. I have found it hard to get used to its user interface where it differs from Lynx (like having to hold down the *Shift* key while using the mouse, to select or paste text)—but I'm coming around.

Lately, I have found some irritants with Firefox, so I have started experimenting with Google Chrome (chrome.google.com). I run Google Chrome in my Fedora VM. There's a nice how-to at <http://bit.ly/M8BhFZ>. Install it with:

```
cd /tmp
wget https://dl-ssl.google.com/linux/linux_signing_key.pub
rpm --import linux_signing_key.pub
echo "[google] name=Google Chrome 32-bit \
baseurl=dl.google.com/linux/chrome/rpm/stable/i386" >> /etc/yum.
repos.d/google.repo
yum install google-chrome-stable
```

I had been vaguely considering Google Chrome for some time, but my intention turned to action when I found that one application (Remedy) was causing Firefox to abort several times a day. I found this behaviour particularly galling because I typically have four or five Firefox windows running, each with up to ten tabs open. Every time Firefox crashed, there was a period during which my machine was unusable till all my sessions were restored. I now run Remedy in Google Chrome, and have not had a problem. It's too early

for me to ditch Firefox altogether, but the two browsers are sufficiently similar so it's not onerous for me to run both.

Instant messaging

Microsoft Lync is an instant messaging client used with Microsoft Lync Server. In its place, I run Pidgin (*pidgin.im*) under Fedora. It is also available in CentOS, but not pidgin-sipe, which is needed to talk to Lync. Pidgin allows you to talk to anyone using a variety of messaging protocols including AIM, MSN, Yahoo!, Jabber, Bonjour, Gadu-Gadu, ICQ, IRC, Novell Groupwise, QQ, Lotus Sametime, SILC, Simple and Zephyr. These protocols are implemented using a modular, easy-to-use design. To use a protocol, just add an account using the account editor. Pidgin supports many common features of other clients, as well as many unique features, such as Perl scripting, TCL scripting and C plug-ins. Pidgin is not affiliated with or endorsed by America Online, Microsoft Corporation, Yahoo! Inc, or ICQ Inc. Install it with `yum install pidgin pidgin-sipe`.

Software for conversion

In the previous sections, my focus was inter-operation. To my mind, this section is at least as important. In the Microsoft world, your co-workers tend to reach for Word almost by reflex. Quite often, I am sent Word documents that contain a few lines of text, something that I think would be more appropriate if created in Notepad or WordPad, or better yet, simply entered directly in an email. If they don't send me attachments, then their emails are sent as HTML. Most of the time, it is overkill.

When it comes to lists, or any sort of tabular data, the choice is often Excel. There may be no intention to perform any sort of calculations—and yet, strangely, Excel seems to be the application of choice. For most of the operations I want to perform on this data, both Word and Excel documents are completely inappropriate. In the past, I tried to ask for documents in a more useful format, but often my requests were met with blank looks. I have since gathered a number of tools to allow me to convert such data to something more satisfactory.

Word documents

For a long time, my tool of choice was Antiword (www.winfield.demon.nl/). Antiword is a free MS-Word reader. It converts the documents from Word 2, 6, 7, 97, 2000, 2002, and 2003, to text, Postscript, and XML/DocBook. Antiword tries to keep the layout of the document intact. Install it with `yum -y install antiword`. Total download size is 175 k.

I use Antiword from NMH to 'render' MS Word attachments. My resume (CV) is in Word format (.doc). I found that all placement agencies accepted this format and some accepted nothing else. It was originally created for me in MS Word. Since then, I have used OpenOffice to make